

The Impact of Organizational Change on Emotions

Chapter 2 — Managing and Leading People

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Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, we will be able to:

- **Distinguish** between emotions and moods in the context of organizational change.
- **Analyze** the psychological impact of change on employees.
- **Evaluate** the "Change Curve" and its stages.
- **Understand** the concept of Emotional Labor.
- **Apply** Emotional Intelligence (EI) frameworks to leadership strategies.

The Nature of Emotions

To manage change, we must understand what we are managing.

Definition: Emotions

Intense feelings directed at someone or something. They are reactions to an object or event (e.g., a restructuring announcement).

Distinction: Moods

Moods are less intense, lack a contextual stimulus, and last longer than emotions.

Relevance: Change triggers specific *emotions* (fear, excitement) which, if unmanaged, calcify into negative *moods* (cynicism).

Change as an Emotional Event

Organizational change is often planned rationally but experienced emotionally.

- **Loss of Control:** Employees feel things are being "done to" them.
- **Uncertainty:** Triggers the brain's threat response.
- **Identity Crisis:** "Who am I if my role changes?"

"The failure of change initiatives is often not due to strategy, but to the failure to account for human emotion."

The Spectrum of Emotional Responses

Reactions are not binary; they exist on a continuum.

Negative Valence

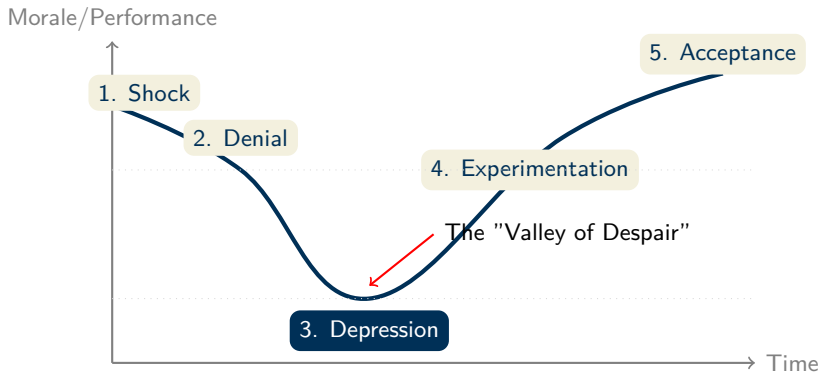
- **Anxiety:** Fear of the unknown.
- **Anger:** Violation of the psychological contract.
- **Sadness:** Grief for the "old way."

Positive Valence

- **Excitement:** Anticipation of growth.
- **Hope:** Belief in a better future.
- **Relief:** Escaping a poor status quo.

Mixed Emotions: It is common for employees to feel both excitement and fear simultaneously.

The Emotional Change Curve



Concept

The management of feeling to create a publicly observable facial and bodily display. Employees must "act" to fit the organizational mood.

Two Types of Acting:

1. **Surface Acting:** Faking the required emotion (e.g., smiling while angry). Leads to burnout and exhaustion.
2. **Deep Acting:** Trying to actually feel the required emotion (e.g., trying to empathize with the new vision). Less stressful but cognitive demanding.

Emotional Intelligence (EI)

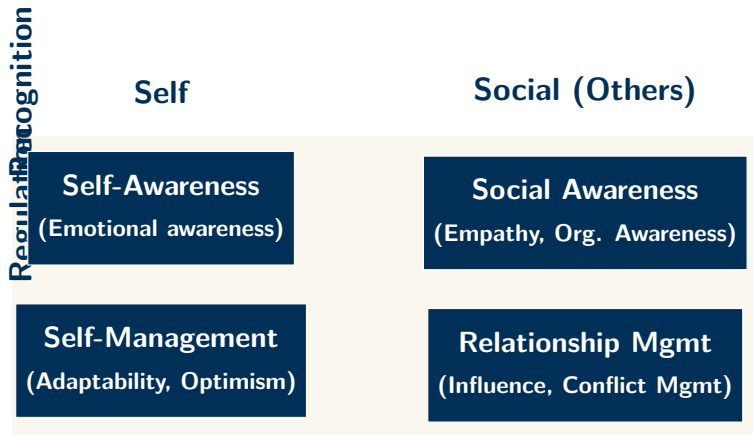
EI is a critical competency for leading change. It is the ability to recognize, understand, and manage our own emotions and the emotions of others.

Why EI Matters in Change

Leaders with high EI can:

- Detect resistance early.
- Build trust through empathy.
- Model resilience.

The EI Competency Model



Culture and Display Rules

Every organization has "Display Rules"—unwritten norms about what emotions are safe to express.

Toxic Culture	Healthy Culture
"Check your emotions at the door."	"It's okay to feel anxious."
Focus on rationality only.	Focus on the whole person.
Fear is punished.	Fear is discussed.

Risk: If culture suppresses negative emotions, they don't disappear—they go underground and sabotage the change.

Strategies for Leaders

How can we sustain change through people?

- **Ventilation:** Create safe spaces/forums for employees to voice concerns without judgment.
- **Validation:** Acknowledge that the transition is difficult. Don't "sugarcoat" the reality.
- **Modeling:** Leaders must demonstrate their own journey through the change curve.
- **Consistency:** Ensure actions match the emotional messaging.

Golden Rule

Connect with the *heart* before asking for the *hand*.

Summary:

1. Emotions are central, not peripheral, to the change process.
2. Resistance is often an emotional reaction to loss or fear.
3. The Change Curve helps predict and manage employee reactions.
4. High Emotional Intelligence (EI) is a prerequisite for successful Change Leadership.

Thank You

Questions?